

Jaslok and Lilavati hospitals in Mumbai in the 1990s. Globally, about 15 to 18 per cent of women, 8 to 10 per cent of men and 4 to 6 per cent of children suffer from headache disorders, says WHO, figures that are paralleled by India. Migraine is 19th among all cases of years lived with disability and up to one adult in 20 gets the less well-recognised chronic daily headache (CDH). Doctors report rising footfalls. "In the last two years, the surge of headache patients has risen. One out of five in our outpatient unit today comes for this," says neurologist Sudhir Kumar of Apollo Hospitals at Jubilee Hills, Hyderabad. "Yet, only one-third of all headache sufferers consult a doctor, while the remaining do their own patchwork cures with painkillers," he says.

But there's a silver lining to the bad news. "Headache research stands at a perfect crossroads, when science, clinical diagnosis and pharmacology are coming together and an era of ignorance is turning into one of exciting discoveries," says Ravishankar. "If scientists are uncovering new pain

THE NEW GENERATION OF PET SCANNERS CAN TELL SCIENTISTS MUCH MORE OF HOW THE BRAIN WORKS, AND IT'S NOT SO SIMPLE

pathways in the brain, the pharma sector is coming up with targeted 'designer drugs' on the basis of their research and clinicians are responding with better treatment modalities."

Ravishankar often gets patients who have given up MBAs, got pink slips at work and are on the verge of divorce because of extreme headaches. "We may not still have the cure, but 60 to 70 per cent patients can be helped today," he says. Neurologist Sumit Singh, who started the headache clinic at the All India Institute of Medical Sciences (AIIMS) in 2004, agrees: "Headaches are now treated as serious, biologically based

disorders at par with epilepsy or Alzheimer's disease."

That "revolution" was very much in evidence to Raj when she went over to the AIIMS headache clinic. She had heard about the avant-garde treatment being used there, shots of wrinkle-fighter Botox, botulinum toxin type A, included. "Injecting botox inhibits the neurotransmitter acetylcholine from relaying messages from the brain, which relaxes the clenching and thereby eases pain," says Singh. For Raj, those injections on her forehead and nape have worked wonders. "They have made me functional," she smiles. She is not the only one to feel this way.

Over 44 patients treated in the last two years at AIIMS have reported between 50 and 70 per cent improvement in headache severity. All were earlier on at least four daily drugs. "Their analgesic requirement has dropped by 60 per cent and 'worst headache days' have disappeared," says Singh.

First, let's decode the jargon. Headaches fall into two broad bands: primary (those that are standalone) and secondary (those that result from other illnesses). The most common type of primary headache is the tension headache, which is caused by muscle-clenching. "A couple of aspirins and a good night's sleep may be all that's

